

Some promoters paid cash to Ketan to inflate their stock price (some like Zee would later claim that the funds they gave him were for buying other companies' shares), while some allotted shares of their companies to Ketan and his associates way below the market price. Later, the Joint Parliamentary Committee probing the stock market scam of 2001 would name Adani, HFCL, DSQ Software, Cadila Healthcare, Essel, Kopran and Nirma among the companies that provided funds to Ketan.

Stocks that took Ketan's fancy soared to unbelievable levels, making him the new Pied Piper of Dalal Street. On tip-offs, traders blindly lapped up the stocks he was supposedly buying, whether it was true or not, fuelling their rise. If Harshad Mehta was the face of the 1991 bull market, Ketan Parekh was the undisputed poster boy of the bull run that began in January 1999 and lasted about eighteen months.

But to say that Ketan alone was responsible for the spectacular rise in every stock that he had spotted first would be to overrate his trading prowess. There were limits to how much even the most skilled of operators could influence fund managers and stock prices once trading volumes crossed a certain threshold. In the face of frenzied retail action or herd behaviour among fund managers, operators are quite ineffective.

Some of the stocks Ketan identified as potential multi-baggers subsequently fetched a huge following among institutional investors, more as a result of the worldwide craze for technology stocks rather than for the business models of the companies. Like Harshad before him, Ketan was not the one who created the wave; he merely rode it skilfully.

Harshad and Ketan were studies in contrast, though it was widely believed that Ketan was being mentored by the erstwhile Big Bull. By a strange twist of fate, Ketan's rise to fame coincided with the declining fortunes of Harshad, whose comeback attempt through BPL, Videocon and Sterlite flopped miserably.

Harshad was brash and flamboyant, and loved to be in the headlines. Ketan managed to keep a low profile for a long time, only too aware of the perils of being in the spotlight. But as the size of his positions kept growing, it became harder for him to stay in the shadows. If Harshad was outspoken and flashy, Ketan was soft-spoken and reclusive. One of Harshad's major weaknesses, according to those who knew him well, was his inability to sell a stock in good time. He was good at driving up prices to bizarre heights,